



Champions assemble: 1-3: Avani Lekhara, Sumit Antil and Navdeep Singh produced stellar performances in the Paris Paralympics last year, each winning gold in shooting and javelin. 4: Manu Bhaker won two bronze medals in the Paris Olympics, narrowly missing out on a third medal in the 25m air pistol shooting final. **Facing page:** Khadse, along with Union Minister of Youth Affairs and Sports Mansukh Mandaviya (second from left), felicitate the Indian paralympians from Paris 2024. GETTY IMAGES, REUTERS & PTI

the age fraud problem.

The proposed Sports Regulatory Board under the 2024 National Sports Governance Bill has raised concerns of government interference, potentially clashing with IOC norms. Do you anticipate friction with international bodies, and how can India navigate this risk?

I think it was necessary to do this because, as you can see, there are so many issues within these federations right now. For example, we have 100 federations, and about 60% or 70% of them are embroiled in litigation, and because of this, many athletes are suffering. The government is not going to take away the rights of the federations through this bill. This regulation will help them focus more on sport. There are ongoing dialogues with the IOC and other international federations to align policies and reduce potential friction.

What can we do to address the factionalism within NSFs and the legal challenges that keep coming up?

Long-term stabilisation can be achieved by establishing independent, transparent sports bodies with clear mandates, robust legal frameworks, and inclusive decision-making processes to reduce internal conflicts. The recently introduced Sports Governance Bill may provide a long-term solution to this. Establishing sports tribunals will also help address protracted legal disputes.

When can we expect the government to table the National Sports Governance Bill in Parliament?

The bill is expected to be tabled at an appropriate time after due consultations and requisite revisions to ensure comprehensive coverage of sports governance issues.

How do you evaluate the performance of our athletes at the Paris Olympics and Paralympics?

The performance had mixed outcomes: while some disciplines showed promise, the overall medal tally fell short of expectations, highlighting the need for further strategic improvements in training and infrastructure.

However, we must note that six of our athletes finished in fourth place at the Paris Olympics. This is an improvement — a step towards better performance.

The Paralympians showed tremendous improvement and increased their medal count to 29. The government is trying its best to provide better facilities for para-athletes, and their numbers will increase even further in the coming years.

The government has reduced the number of athletes under the reconstituted TOPS (Target Olympic Podium Scheme) list following a less-than-satisfactory performance at the Paris Games. What led to this decision, and how will it impact athlete preparation going forward?

The reduction reflects a strategic move to concentrate resources on the most competitive athletes. This focused approach aims to improve training quality and performance, though it may require transitional adjustments for those removed. We have also announced the Target Asian Games Group (TAGG) with an initial list of 37 athletes.

Neeraj Chopra and others have called for elite international events to be held in India. Are there concrete plans to host competitions like the Diamond League soon?

More events are happening in India now, compared to earlier. While infrastructure enhancements and regulatory adjustments are in progress, concrete plans will be finalised as these efforts mature in consultation with the NSFs. India has already demonstrated its capability to host large-scale events, with the Khelo India Games becoming an annual phenomenon.

India missed its double-digit medal target for the Paris Olympics. What specific strategies are being developed by your ministry and SAI to meet this goal at the 2028 Los Angeles Games?

Our performance over the last six or seven years has improved significantly compared to where we were earlier. We are providing all the equipment and facilities required by the athletes and ensuring they receive the best coaching, wherever they want in the world. Therefore, our